

# HONG WANG

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## Appointments

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**Harvard University**, Department of Economics

*Aug. 2026–Mar. 2027*

Mary Beth and Chris Gordon Postdoctoral Fellow in Gender Inequality

## Education

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**Boston University**

*Sep. 2020–Aug. 2026 (expected)*

Ph.D. in Economics

M.A. in Political Economy

*Aug. 2024*

**New York University**

*May 2018*

B.A. in Mathematics and Economics, *cum laude*

## Fields

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**Primary Fields:** Economic History, Political Economy

**Secondary Fields:** Gender Economics, Media Economics

**Methods:** Historical Data Construction, Natural Language Processing, Deep Learning, Geospatial Analysis

## References

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**Martin Fiszbein**

Boston University

fiszbein@bu.edu

**Claudia Goldin**

Harvard University

cgoldin@harvard.edu

**James Feigenbaum**

Boston University

jamesf@bu.edu

**Melissa Dell**

Harvard University

melissadell@fas.harvard.edu

**Robert Margo**

Boston University

margora@bu.edu

## Research

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Research Assistant to James Feigenbaum, Boston University

*2022–2023*

## Teaching

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Teaching Fellow, Introductory Microeconomics and Macroeconomics, Boston University

*2021–2025*

## Job Market Paper

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**What Killed the ERA? The Role of Entrepreneurs in the Marketplace of Ideas and Policy**

I provide the first causal estimates of Phyllis Schlafly's influence on public opinion and legislative behavior during the Equal Rights Amendment ratification fight. Exploiting quasi-random topographic variation in CBS *Spectrum* radio and television exposure, I find that exposed counties in five pivotal states experienced a 0.21 standard deviation decline in sentiment toward women's rights. In Illinois, a one standard deviation within-district increase in CBS FM exposure reduced legislators' ERA support by 18.4 percentage points. CBS television exposure and geochemically instrumented CBS AM exposure increased legislators' adoption of Schlafly's ERA framing.

## Working Papers

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**Grounded: Soil Geochemistry and the Causal Effects of Political AM Radio**

I show that applying the Irregular Terrain Model to historical AM radio introduces non-classical measurement error because the model is designed for FM frequencies and terrain obstruction. I implement the physically appropriate Low Frequency/Medium Frequency ground-wave model and develop path-integrated geochemical

instruments for soil-conductivity-driven propagation. The corrected approach recovers a negative causal effect of Father Coughlin’s broadcasts on FDR’s 1936 vote share, but no causal effect of Nazi AM radio exposure on Nazi electoral support.

### **A Republic, Not a Democracy: The Legacy of John Birch Society Membership**

I digitize and geocode comprehensive 1987 John Birch Society membership rolls, recovering roughly 50,000 members from 1,870 pages of archival dot-matrix printing using a custom deep-learning OCR pipeline. Counties with more JBS members produced significantly more Department of Justice-charged January 6 defendants, fully absorbing the manufacturing-decline variable emphasized in prior work, while showing less populist electoral shift toward Donald Trump. The paper links contemporary political extremism to long-standing conservative organizational infrastructure.

### **A Choice, Not an Echo: Cultural Matching in the Marketplace of Ideas and Policy**

I develop a nonpriced search-and-matching model in which dormant arguments become powerful only when accumulated idea stock meets accumulated unmet demand through a scarce cultural entrepreneur. The model formalizes activation as a three-input matching problem—dormant stock, unmatched demand, and scarce matcher—and separates platform intensity, which moves attitudes and votes, from transmissibility, which moves rhetoric.

## **Papers in Progress**

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### **The Evangelical Origins of the Welfare Queen**

*with Brianna Alderman and Gabby Toborg*

Using Christian media exposure, we study whether substitution between private charity and public welfare created incentives for churches to advocate against the welfare state by turning congregational sentiment against welfare recipients.

### **Deep Learning for Census Linking**

*with Abhishek Arora and James Feigenbaum*

Using Sentence-BERT, we develop cosine-similarity methods to improve name-variant disambiguation over time for historical census record linkage.

## **Seminars & Conferences**

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Harvard University, Economic History Graduate Workshop

*2023, 2024, 2025*

London School of Economics, Queer Conference

*2025*

## **Research Grants**

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BU Institute for Economic Development Research Grant, Boston University, \$3,000

*2025*

## **Academic Service**

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Organizer, BU–Harvard Summer Deep Learning in Economics Reading Group

*Summer 2024*

## **Additional Experience**

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Mentor, Minds Matter Boston

*2022–2025*

Independent study and travel

*2018–2020*

Fellow, Global Citizen Year, Florianópolis, Brazil

*2013–2014*

## **Languages, Software Skills, and Citizenship**

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**Languages:** English, Italian, Portuguese

**Software Skills:** Python, PyTorch, QGIS, L<sup>A</sup>T<sub>E</sub>X

**Citizenship:** United States